

Data & AI Leadership Exchange



2026 AI & Data Leadership Executive Benchmark Survey

*Global Chief Data, Analytics, and AI Officers,
and Corporate Technology and Business Heads, on the State of
Leadership, Innovation and Transformation in an AI Future*

Executive Summary of Findings

Survey and Findings Authored by Randy Bean

With a Foreword by Thomas H. Davenport and Randy Bean

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Foreword

Are we at “peak AI?” Although many are questioning whether companies are getting sufficient value from AI, it would be hard to find stronger endorsements for the technology than the responses to this year’s AI and Data Leadership Executive Survey. Virtually every data and AI leader in the survey believes that AI is a high priority for their organization, has plans to spend more on it, and even confirms that their company is getting measurable business value from their AI investments.

There are other indicators as well of the high priorities put on data and AI. The percentage of companies having a Chief Data (and Analytics or AI) Officer is the highest ever, at 90%. Seventy percent of respondents believe the CDO role is “successful and established”—twenty points above last year and double the 2023 percentage. Although there is still room for improvement in AI being implemented in production at-scale, 90% feel they are beyond the pure experimentation stage. Almost 90% feel that safeguards and governance for AI are in place. Overall, data and AI feel quite institutionalized at this point.

Is there any flaw with this lovely picture? As always, nothing is perfect. One of the flaws that we’ve seen year after year is that the primary obstacles to effective use of data and AI are almost entirely human rather than technological. This year the highest-ever percentage in this survey (93%) pointed to human issues—culture and change management—as the key challenge to data and AI adoption. Only 7% blamed technology. But how many CDOs spend 93% of their own efforts addressing human issues? This issue strongly suggests a need for closer collaboration with Chief Human Resource Officers and the establishment of culture and change management capabilities within the CDO and AI functions.

The other flaw also involves organizational issues—in this case the management of AI. Given all the attention to AI in organizations, it’s no surprise that a growing percentage of companies (38%) have named Chief AI Officers. But where in the organization should that job report? There is no consensus in the survey results. We believe that the CAIO should report to the CDO, but that reporting relationship is only 30% of survey respondents. In other organizations AI reports variously to business leadership (27%), technology leadership (34%), or transformation leadership (9%).

We’re not sure this lack of consensus is a good thing for organizations. The confusion about where responsibility for AI belongs may be contributing to the widespread perception among the media and investing communities that AI isn’t producing enough value. Otherwise, however, this appears to be the “Golden Age of AI,” and of the leaders mandated with delivering business value.

Thomas H. Davenport and Randy Bean

Introduction

This is the 15th annual AI & Data Executive Leadership Benchmark Survey findings report.

I first began surveying the most senior data and analytics leaders of Fortune 1000 and leading global organizations in 2012. It was not long before that time that [data and analytics were considered back-office functions](#), often relegated to the sidelines of corporate decision making. This was until the financial crisis of 2008-2009, which triggered the transformation of data and analytics into a C-suite function. But, even then, progress was gradual.

In the first survey conducted in 2012, just 12% of leading companies had appointed a Chief Data Officer (CDO). Now, in this year's survey, 90% of firms report having appointed a CDO, with another 38% having appointed Chief AI Officer (CAIO). In addition, 52% of respondents now say that a CAIO or equivalent AI leader should be appointed. We've come a long way.

The recognition of the value of data has been further enhanced by the accelerating arrival of AI. This year, 99% of survey participants state that investments in data & AI are a top organizational priority. While it is axiomatic to say that great AI is predicated upon an organization having great data, it is gratifying to appreciate that 93% of companies now report that interest in AI has led to a greater focus on data.

Of further note in this year's survey findings is the 83% of respondents who now believe that AI is likely to become the most transformational technology in a generation, with 97% stating that they believe that the overall impact of AI will be beneficial.

It has also been gratifying to see the interest that publication of these annual survey findings have generated, with coverage in publications including [Harvard Business Review](#) and [MIT Sloan Management Review](#), and referenced in [The Wall Street Journal](#), [The New York Times](#), and [The Economist](#). One can safely say that the survey has become an established industry benchmark.

Each year, this survey is distinguished and uniquely differentiated by its highly curated participation. Respondents are invited to participate by invitation-only, with participation limited to the most senior AI & data leaders of Fortune 1000 companies and leading global brands.

The response to this year's survey was once again strong—with senior AI and data executives from nearly 110 leading companies participating. This year, 96% of survey respondents identified themselves as C-executives or C-executive equivalents within their organization, with 90% of respondents holding the title of Chief Data Officer (CDO), Chief Data & Analytics Officer (CDAO), Chief AI Officer (CAIO), or Enterprise/Global Head of Data & AI.

Thank you to all of the Data & AI leaders who participated in this year's survey.

Your experiences and knowledge have, once again, made this survey the benchmark for AI & Data leadership. As always, I am very appreciative and grateful for your participation!

Randy Bean

Executive Summary of Findings

Notable among the principal findings of this year's survey are these ten notable trends:

1. **Investment in Data and AI is Nearly Universal** – This year, 99.1% of companies surveyed said that investment in data and AI is a top organizational priority. In addition, 90.9% of those surveyed say that their organization is increasing its level of investment.
2. **AI Investment is Fueling Data Investment** – It is widely recognized by now that great AI depends upon great data. This year, 92.7% of the firms surveyed report that interest in AI has led to a greater focus on data.
3. **The Chief Data Officer (CDO) Role is Now Widely Accepted** – There is reason for optimism among Chief Data Officers (CDOs)--90% of companies now report having appointed a CDO, with 69.8% saying the role is well established, up from 47.6% last year.
4. **Companies are also Appointing Chief AI Officers (CAIOs)** – The number of companies have appointed CAIO is increasing—up to 38.5% from 33.1% last year. More than half of firms now say that a CAIO should be appointed.
5. **AI is now in Production at Most Companies** – AI adoption has accelerated. Firms saying that AI is now in production at scale increased from 4.7% to 39.1% in 2 years, with firms with AI in limited production having grown from 24.5% to 54.5% during this period.
6. **People Represent Greatest Impediment to AI Adoption** – People and change, not technology, continue to be the greatest obstacles to AI adoption according to 93.2% of firms. Organizations continue to struggle with changes to business processes, training, education, and cultural transformation.
7. **AI seen as Most Transformational Technology in a Generation** – A growing number of companies now believe that AI will be the most transformational technology in a generation, up from 64.2% two years ago to 82.7% this year.
8. **Organizations are Progressing with Responsible AI** – More organizations are seeing Responsible AI is an essential component of their AI plans, with 79.4% believing that Responsible AI is a top corporate priority, up from 68.8% last year, and 88.7% reporting these guardrails are now in place, up from 62.9% 2 years ago.
9. **Data & AI Investments are Delivering Increased Business Value** – Notably, the percentage of firms realizing high or significant business value from their data & AI investments improved from 46% to 54% this year. A strong step in the right direction.
10. **Executives believe that AI will have a Beneficial Impact** – Lastly, 97.1% of executives see the overall impact of AI as being beneficial in the long run. Like any historical technology transformation, the lasting benefits tend to unfold over time.

Participation

The 2026 survey participation reflects diverse community of data and AI leadership participants across industries, roles, and geographies. Participants include long-tenured Chief Data Officer as well as newly minted Chief AI Officers from many of the largest and most well-known companies in the world. A recap of participation in this year's survey is as follows:

- This year, 96.4 of the participants in this year's survey held the most senior data and AI leadership positions within their respective firms.
- The largest representation continues to be from leading financial services firms, which comprise 42.7% of survey respondents.
- Industry diversification continues to grow, with significant representation from leading health care and life sciences companies, retail and consumer packaged goods providers, comprising 26.3% of survey participants.
- Industry representation encompasses companies and organizations operating in a broad range of diverse industries, comprising 31.0% of this year's survey respondents.

Exhibit A | Survey Participation Breakdown by Industry

<u>Industry Participation</u>	<u>2022</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Financial Services	60.0%	57.3%	50.9%	40.2%	42.7%
Healthcare Life Sciences	21.0%	16.1%	14.8%	16.5%	12.7%
Retail Consumer Packaged Goods	8.0%	9.7%	11.1%	12.6%	13.6%
Other Industries	11.0%	16.9%	23.2%	30.7%	31.0%

Exhibit B | Survey Participation by Organizational Role

<u>Respondent Role</u>	<u>2022</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
AI & Data Leadership CDO CDAO CAIO	77.0%	84.6%	89.8%	90.6%	90.0%
Technology Leadership CIO CTO	14.0%	8.0%	4.6%	3.9%	2.7%
Business Leadership CEO COO	4.0%	1.6%	0.9%	1.6%	1.8%
Transformation Leadership	1.0%	2.4%	1.9%	1.6%	1.8%
Other Executive	4.0%	3.4%	2.8%	2.3%	3.6%

Exhibit C | Survey Participation by Geographical Location

<u>Geography</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
North America	92.6%	85.0%	88.2%
International	7.4%	15.0%	11.8%

The State of AI & Data in 100+ Fortune 1000 and Global Leadership Brands

Companies by Industry

Financial Services

AIG
 Ally Financial
 AML RightSource
 American Century
 Amica
 AmTrust
 Apollo
 Balyasny Asset Mgmt
 Bloomberg
 BNY Mellon
 Bread Financial
 CapitalOne
 Centene
 Chubb
 Cigna
 Citigroup
 Citizens Bank
 Equifax
 Fannie Mae
 Fidelity Investments
 First Citizens Bank
 Freddie Mac
 Goldman Sachs
 Grupo InterCorp
 Huntington Bank
 Invesco
 JP Morgan Chase
 KeyBank
 Liberty Mutual
 M&T Bank
 Mastercard

Financial Services

MetLife
 Mizuho
 Moody's
 Morgan Stanley
 Morningstar
 New York Life
 NXT Capital
 Regions Bank
 Reinsurance Group
 S&P Global
 Scotia Bank
 Societe Generale
 TD Bank
 TIAA
 USAA
 Vanguard
 VISA

Media, Arts & Sports
 Boston Red Sox
 CNN
 Consumer Reports
 Creative Artists Agency
 The Economist
 Hearst
 New York Islanders
 Nielsen
 NFL
 Universal Music Group

Retail & Food

Carrefour
 Chipotle
 Colgate Palmolive
 Costco
 Danone
 Just Eat Takeaway
 Levi Strauss
 Lowes
 Mars
 Mondelez
 Niagara Bottling
 Rich Products
 Schnucks Markets
 Starbucks
 Swire Coca Cola
 Yum Brands

Health & Life Sciences

Bristol-Meyers Squibb
 Genentech
 Gilead
 Health Care Services
 Optum Health
 Orlando Health
 Otsuka
 Parexel
 Quest Diagnostics
 Sanofi
 Thermo Fisher Scientific
 UCLA Health
 Zoetis

Technology

ADP
 Applied Materials
 Google
 IBM
 Michelin
 Rakuten
 Ralliant
 TE Connectivity

Energy

FERC
 National Grid
 Oceaneering
 Schneider Electric

Telecommunications

AT&T
 Verizon

Aviation & Automotive

Bentley
 Car Gurus
 Emirates
 Ford Motors
 Southwest Airlines

Professional Services

Arup
 Colliers
 Sidley Austin

Executives served in senior AI & data leadership roles with these firms during 2025.

Finding 1 | Investment in Data and AI is Nearly Universal

This year's finding that data and AI are a top priority for the world's leading companies should come as no surprise. AI capabilities and solutions have emerged at an unprecedented pace during the past three years. While Exhibit F illustrates that AI has existed in various forms for many decades, the ability of companies to integrate AI into mainstream business processes only took off following the introduction of Generative AI in November 2022.

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As shown in Exhibit D, 99.1% of this year's respondents say that investment in data and AI is a top organizational priority, with 90.9% noting that their firm is increasing its investment in data and AI.

Exhibit D | State of Data & AI Investment

<u>State of Data & AI Investment</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Investments in Data & AI are a Top Organizational Priority	87.9%	90.5%	99.1%
Our Organization is Increasing its Investment in Data & AI	82.2%	85.7%	90.9%

Exhibit E provides a more granular explanation of the top line findings. It shows that 32.7% of respondents view AI investment as the highest priority of their firm, up sharply from 18.1% the previous year, while those that view investment in AI as not a priority has dropped to nearly zero.

Exhibit E | Data & AI a Top Organizational Priority

<u>Is investment in data & AI a top organizational priority?</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Yes, AI is highest priority for our organization	18.1%	32.7%
Yes, AI is a high priority for our organization	72.4%	66.4%
No, AI is not a high priority for our organization	9.4%	0.9%

Exhibit F reflects the long history that a significant number of organizations have had with AI over the years. While the majority of companies—56.1%, have been working with AI for less than 5 years, it is notable that 10.3% of companies say they have had a history of engaging with early forms of AI and machine learning for over a decade.

Exhibit F | History of AI Use

<u>How long has your company been using AI?</u>	<u>2026</u>
Less than 2 years	23.3%
3-5 years	32.8%
6-10 years	33.6%
11-24 years	6.6%
More than 25 years	3.7%

Finding 2 | AI Investment is Fueling Data Investment

It was not that long ago that data was seen as a back-office function and relegated to the sidelines. For years, companies invested in data quality and data warehouse initiatives to bring their data together, but these initiatives were often viewed as the purview of data architects and the data sciences teams that used this data and analysis.

Times have changed. Companies have come to recognize that trusted data provides the foundation for quality AI. For this reason, companies are investing their time, energy, and money in establishing the data foundations needed to support their AI applications.

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Exhibit G highlights the spotlight that has been turned upon data, with 92.7% of respondents saying that interest in AI has led to a greater focus on data within their firms.

Exhibit G | Investment in Data

<u>Investment in Data</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Interest in AI Has Led to a Greater Focus on Data	93.7%	92.7%

Exhibit H provides a more granular breakdown, showing that 38.5% now say that data has become a top priority of their firm, up from 33.1% last year.

Exhibit H | Data as a Top Priority

<u>Has interest in AI led to a greater focus on data?</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Yes, data has become a top priority for our organization	33.1%	38.5%
Yes, there is a greater focus on data than previous years	60.6%	54.1%
No, there has not been a greater focus on data so far	6.3%	7.3%

Finding 3 | The Chief Data Officer (CDO) Role is Now Widely Accepted

Prior to the financial services crisis of 2008-2009, the role of Chief Data Officer (CDO) was largely unknown, with only a handful of data-intensive companies having appointed anyone to the role. Then, everything changed. By 2012, when this survey was first conducted, 12.0% of firms had named a Chief Data Officer, mostly among large financial services firms. As the role evolved from a risk and regulatory focus to a more expansive business growth focus, the role expanded in many organizations into a Chief Data and Analytics Officer (CDAO) function.

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As shown in Exhibit I, five years later, by 2017, 55.9% of firms had appointed a CDO/CDAO, and within a decade, by 2022, this had grown to 73.7%. Today, 90% of firms have appointed a CDO/CDAO and the role has matured to be viewed as successful and well established.

Exhibit I | Appointment of a Chief Data Officer

<u>CDO/CDAO Appointed</u>	<u>2012</u>	<u>2017</u>	<u>2021</u>	<u>2022</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Yes	12.0%	55.9%	65.0%	73.7%	82.6%	83.2%	84.3%	90.0%
No	88.0%	44.1%	35.0%	26.3%	17.4%	16.8%	15.7%	10.0%

This year marks a notable point of arrival for the CDO/CDAO role, with a noteworthy increase in the number of respondents saying that the role is successful and well established within their firm rising sharply from 47.6% to 69.8%, as shown in Exhibit J.

Exhibit J | Success of the Chief Data Officer Role

<u>Success of the CDO/CDAO Role</u>	<u>2020</u>	<u>2021</u>	<u>2022</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Successful and Established	27.9%	33.3%	40.2%	35.5%	51.0%	47.6%	69.8%
Nascent and Evolving Turnover	69.6%	64.0%	57.3%	61.8%	42.7%	47.6%	27.0%
Failure	2.5%	2.7%	2.5%	2.7%	6.3%	4.8%	3.2%

Exhibit K reflects the progression over time in the function of the CDO/CDAO role from a defensive role focused on regulatory and efficiency requirements to an offensive role focused on innovation and business growth. This year, 85.5% of firms report that CDO/CDAOs are focused on innovation and business growth, a sharp increase from just three years ago.

Exhibit K | Focus of the Chief Data Officer Role

<u>Primary Focus of the CDO/CDAO Function</u>	<u>2020</u>	<u>2021</u>	<u>2022</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Offense Growth Innovation	54.6%	70.1%	64.3%	61.8%	62.3%	80.0%	85.5%
Defense Regulatory Efficiency	45.4%	29.2%	35.7%	38.2%	37.7%	20.0%	14.5%

Most Chief Data Officers historically reported into the Chief Information Officer of their organization. These reporting relationships have evolved over time as the role has become more closely aligned to business outcomes.

As shown in Exhibit L, 33.6% of CDO/CDAOs report to business leadership with another 9.1% reporting to transformation leadership, a growing trend over the past decade. In a few instances, the CDO/CDAO role is now a part of the company operating committee. It will be worth monitoring how these reporting relationships evolve in the next few years as AI becomes a core driver of business operations and profitability.

Exhibit L | Chief Data Officer Reporting Relationship

<u>CDO/CDAO/CAIO Reporting Relationship</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Business Leadership			36.2%	33.6%
Technology Leadership			47.2%	42.7%
Transformation Leadership			11.0%	9.1%
Other			5.6%	14.6%

There is additional good news for Chief Data Officers. While average CDO/CDAO tenures have historically been less than 2-3 years, the number of Chief Data Officers with tenure exceeding five years has increased from 16.6% to 25.8%, as shown in Exhibit M. This offers further potential evidence of a growing maturity and stability of the CDO/CAO role within firms.

Exhibit M | Chief Data Officer Average Tenures

<u>What has the average tenure been of the CDO in your organization?</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
0-2 years	24.0%	22.6%
2-3 years	29.7%	27.8%
3-4 years	29.7%	23.8%
5+ years	16.6%	25.8%

Lastly, and perhaps most encouraging for the CDO community, Exhibit N shows an increase from 70.8% to 80.6% in the number of respondents that view the Chief Data Officer function as a role that has firmly arrived, and which will become a permanent C-Suite role. It will now be interesting to watch how responsibility for AI is integrated into this function.

Exhibit N | Chief Data Officer Average Tenures

<u>CDO as a C-Suite Role</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
CDO Has Become Permanent C-Suite Role	70.8%	80.6%
CDO is a Transitional Role	29.2%	19.4%

Finding 4 | Companies are also Appointing Chief AI Officers (CAIOs)

As organizations evaluate how best to shepherd AI adoption and creation, use AI to serve their customers, and create sustainable business value, firms are increasingly appointing Chief AI Officers (CAIO) to help organize and manage these efforts. Much as the Chief Data Officer was an entirely new role fifteen years ago, organizations are exploring how best to organize the Chief AI Officer role, including reporting relationships and scope of responsibilities.

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As shown in Exhibit O, 38.5% of organizations now report having named a Chief AI Officer or the equivalent, up from 33.1% last year. In addition, more than half of firms—51.8%, now believe that a CAIO should be appointed, up from 43.9%.

Exhibit O | Appointment of a Chief AI Officer

<u>Chief AI Officer Appointed</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Chief AI Officer Appointed	33.1%	38.5%
Should a CAIO be Appointed	43.9%	51.8%

Exhibit P confirms that the optimal reporting relationship for the Chief AI Officer is still very much a work of progress in its infancy, with CAIOs reporting in similar proportions into the Chief Data Officer function, or into other business and technology leadership functions. It is worth noting that some [organizations are beginning to create a Chief Data, Analytics, and AI Officer \(CDAIO\) role](#). This will be something to monitor in the year ahead.

Exhibit P | Reporting Relationship of Chief AI Officer

<u>CAIO Reporting Relationship</u>	<u>2026</u>
Chief Data Officer (CDO/CDAO)	30.4%
Business Leadership	26.8%
Technology Leadership	33.9%
Transformation Leadership	8.9%

The current state of AI reporting responsibility remains mixed. For most of the organizations that have not appointed a Chief AI Officer, AI continues to be a responsibility of the Chief Data Officer function until structured otherwise. Exhibit Q reflects this current state of AI responsibility.

Exhibit Q | Current State of AI Leadership Responsibility

<u>Responsibility for AI Leadership</u>	<u>2026</u>
Responsibility for AI is Part of the CDO/CDAO Function	69.1% 62.7%

Finding 5 | AI is now in Production at Most Companies

AI adoption is rapidly accelerating. This is one of the most significant of the findings from this year's survey. Most notably, firms that report having implemented AI in production at scale have skyrocketed during the past two years, as well as the number of firms that have implemented AI in limited production. This demonstrates the extent to which firms are committed to integrating AI into their business processes.

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Exhibit R illustrates the dramatic pace of AI adoption within the past two years, showing an increase in firms that have implemented AI in production at scale from just 4.7% two years ago to a significant 39.1% this year. Further, the number of firms that have implemented AI into limited production has grown from 24.5% to 54.5% during this period.

Two years ago, just 29.2% of firms had implemented any AI capabilities into production. This year, 93.6% of companies report that they have AI capabilities in production, with just 6.4% remaining in the early stages of experimentation, testing, planning, and design. The progress has been extraordinary.

Exhibit R | State of AI Implementation Efforts

<u>State of AI Implementation Efforts</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Early Stage: Experimentation, Testing, Planning & Design	70.8%	29.2%	6.4%
Implemented in Limited Production	24.5%	47.2%	54.5%
Implemented in Production At Scale	4.7%	23.6%	39.1%

Finding 6 | People Represent Greatest Impediment to AI Adoption

It should not come as a surprise that even with the significant progress that has been made in moving AI capabilities and processes into production at leading firms, challenges remain and will likely continue to remain for some time. These challenges are not due to technology limitations and restrictions.

These challenges are largely due to “people” issues that are a function of change and what that means in terms of how people and organizations adopt any new technology. Largely classified as change management, these issues relate to changes in business processes, organizational behaviors, education, training, and adoption of new skills.

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Exhibit S highlights the significant gap between the readiness of technology and the readiness of organizations and people to adopt these new technologies. This year, 93.2% of respondents report that cultural challenges represent the greatest impediment to AI adoption within their firms. These challenges can be described as anything from unwillingness to change and adapt to inability to change and adapt.

It’s worth noting that, for the most part, these issues of cultural change and change management have been largely consistent for years, with a further uptick this year.

Exhibit S | Greatest Impediment to AI Adoption

<u>Principal Challenge to Data & AI Adoption</u>	<u>2021</u>	<u>2022</u>	<u>2023</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Cultural Challenges Change Management	92.2%	91.9%	79.8%	77.6%	91.2%	93.2%
Technology Challenges	7.8%	8.1%	20.2%	23.4%	8.8%	6.8%

Finding 7 | AI seen as Most Transformational Technology in a Generation

Technology transformation arrives at a steady pace over time, except at certain periods when the technology transformation is so great as to be considered generational. These technology transformations have been notable throughout history, with the industrial revolution of the 19th century being a notable and well documented example of transformational change. In recent memory, the introduction of the Internet of the late 1990's seems to be most comparable to the current pace of AI transformation.

*

It is noteworthy that this view that AI will be a generationally transformative technology is gaining traction. As illustrated in Exhibit T, just two years ago, a significant but not overwhelming number, 64.2%, believed that AI would have this transformational impact. This year, that number has grown to 82.7%. It will be interesting to monitor this perception in the next year and understand what this means in terms of implications for companies, employees, and customers.

Exhibit T | Transformational Impact of AI

<u>Outlook for AI</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
AI is Likely to be Most Transformational Technology in a Generation	64.2%	78.4%	82.7%

Finding 8 | Organizations are Progressing with Responsible AI

Like any technology, AI is a tool, and its ultimate value and utility depends upon how humans apply, guide, and govern this technology. This is one of the principal responsibilities and greatest challenges that organizations face in the adoption of AI, with success ultimately depending upon the degree to which AI is implemented in a safe and highly responsible manner.

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Exhibit U highlights the challenges that organizations face and their progress in addressing these challenges. This year, 79.4% of respondents report that investment in Responsible AI is a top corporate priority, an increase from 68.8% the previous year. Is it too much to hope that this number will reach 100% in the next few years?

There is good news that 95.3% of firms recognize the critical need for necessary safeguards and guardrails for governing AI. Though, shouldn't this number also be 100%? There is good news to report that progress is being made. This year, 88.7% of firms report that the safeguards and guardrails for Responsible AI use are in place, up from 62.9% two years ago.

Much progress has been made, but there is still more to be done. Responsible AI use will presumably result in better outcomes for everyone in the long run.

Exhibit U | State of Responsible AI

<u>Responsible AI</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Investment in Responsible AI is a Top Corporate Priority		68.8%	79.4%
Need for Safeguards and Guardrails for Governing AI	99.0%	93.7%	95.3%
Safeguards and Guardrails for Governing AI Are In Place	62.9%	75.8%	88.7%

Finding 9 | Data & AI Investments are Delivering Increased Business Value

Companies need to show measurable business value, quantifiable in terms of increased customer satisfaction, improved employee efficiency, and bottom-line profitability, to demonstrate the value of their data and AI investments. It is not enough to chase new technology without showing measurable value and results. This is the bottom-line question that business leaders must ask. Are we getting measurable business value from our data and AI investments?

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This year, as shown in Exhibit V, 97.3% of firms report that they are delivering measurable business value from their data and AI investments, up from 87.0% percent two years ago. Exhibit W qualifies the degree of business value more granularly. For example, the number of organizations reporting a high or significant degree of business value delivered rose from 47.6% last year, to 54.0% this year.

Overall, 91.5% of organizations report modest or better business value from their data and AI investments, up from 80.6% last year. There is still work to be done, but steady progress is being realized.

Exhibit V | Business Value from Data & AI Investments

<u>Business Value from Data & AI Investments</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Delivering Measurable Business Value from Data & AI Investments	87.0%	93.7%	97.3%

Exhibit W | Degree of Business Value from Data & AI Investments

<u>Delivering measurable business value from data & AI investments?</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Yes, a high degree of measurable business value	18.5%	18.3%
Yes, a significant degree of measurable business value	29.1%	35.7%
Yes, a modest but increasing amount of incremental business value	33.0%	37.5%
Yes, a very minimal amount of measurable business value	15.4%	5.6%
No increase is measurable business value so far	4.0%	2.9%

Finding 10 | Executives believe that AI will have a Beneficial Impact

Change is seldom easy. Periods of change transform social orders and individuals. Often it takes perspective to look back and appreciate the outcomes that may not have been evident during periods of change and turmoil. This applies to AI as well. There are many perspectives on the potential impact of AI on the world, from the fearful to the wildly optimistic.

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It is notable that respondents to this year's survey once again believe that when all is said and done, humans will leverage AI technology to have an overall positive impact that will improve customer experiences, increase productivity, and have a beneficial impact. This may be especially true in fields such as healthcare and medicine, where the benefits of AI can improve the quality of life.

Exhibit X shows that an overwhelming 97.1% of respondents believe that the overall impact of AI will be beneficial. It is on this hopeful note that we close out this year's AI and data executive survey report.

Exhibit X | Overall Impact of AI

<u>Long Term Impact of AI</u>	<u>2024</u>	<u>2025</u>	<u>2026</u>
Overall Impact of AI will be Beneficial		93.5%	97.1%

Additional Reading

For additional perspectives on AI and data leadership, innovation, and transformation.

Harvard Business Review

- [Why Your Company Needs a Chief Data, Analytics, and AI Officer](#)

MIT Sloan Management Review

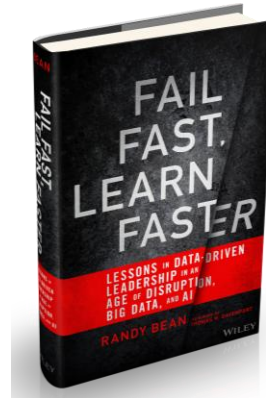
- [Investing in AI Payoffs at **Vanguard**](#)
- [Accelerating Manufacturing Innovation at **Michelin** with Data and AI](#)
- [Building AI Capabilities into Portfolio Companies at **Apollo**](#)
- [TurboTax Meets Turbo Innovation: AI at **Intuit**](#)
- [The GenAI Focus Shifts to Innovation at **Colgate-Palmolive**](#)
- [How GenAI Helps **USAA** Innovate](#)

Forbes

- [How **Ford** Is Embracing AI To Drive Innovation in The Automotive Industry](#)
- [At **Lowe's**, AI Is Laying the Foundation for The Future of Home Improvement](#)
- [How **Starbucks** Is Using Data and AI To Deliver Joy and Connection to Its Customers](#)
- [At **JPMorgan Chase**, AI Innovation Is an Operating Committee Mandate](#)
- [Founded On Technology Innovation, **AT&T** Is Charting a Data and AI Future](#)
- [How **Visa** is Using Data and AI To Transform the Digital Payments Industry](#)
- [How Data and AI Are Driving Business Transformation At **M&T Bank**](#)
- [How **Verizon** Uses Data, Analytics, And AI To Deliver Responsible AI That Drives Innovation](#)
- [**Capital One**: The Ongoing Story of How One Firm Has Been Pioneering Data, Analytics, & AI Innovation for Over Three Decades](#)

About Data & AI Leadership Exchange

Data & AI Leadership Exchange was established by Randy Bean to educate Data & AI Leaders, the Chief Data, Analytics, and AI Officer (CDO/CDAIO) communities, and Fortune 1000 business leaders, on leadership, innovation, and transformation in an AI future.



About Randy Bean

Randy Bean has been an advisor to Fortune 1000 organizations on data and AI leadership for over 4 decades. He is currently a senior advisor, board member, keynote speaker and moderator, contributing author and ex founder and CEO, and has been a participant, observer, chronicler, and leader in the field of data and AI for more than 4 decades.

Randy is the bestselling author of [Fail Fast, Learn Faster: Lessons in Data-Driven Leadership in an Age of Disruption, Big Data, and AI](#), and a regular contributor to [Forbes](#), [Harvard Business Review](#), and [MIT Sloan Management Review](#). He was a former contributor to [The Wall Street Journal](#) and has been referenced and quoted on AI leadership in [The Wall Street Journal](#), [The New York Times](#), and [The Economist](#).

Randy was previously founder and CEO of NewVantage Partners (NVP), a data and AI leadership advisory firm to Fortune 1000 clients, which he founded in 2001 and led for 20 years until its December 2021 acquisition by Paris-based global consultancy Wavestone. He is a frequent industry keynote and panel moderator on the topic of data and AI leadership, and was recognized with the [Lifetime Achievement Award](#) in 2025 for his work in the fields of data and AI.

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